

Tips for Communicating With and About People With Disabilities and Mental Health Conditions

Here are a few points to consider when interacting with people with disabilities and mental health conditions:

- We don't do things **FOR** people with disabilities and mental health conditions. We do things **WITH** people.
- People with disabilities, like all people, are experts on themselves. They know what they like, what they do not like, and what they can and cannot do. If you are uncertain what to do; "Just Ask." Most people would rather answer a question upfront rather than being in a potentially uncomfortable situation.
- Offer to help in a dignified manner with sensitivity and respect. Be prepared to have the offer declined. If the offer is accepted, listen to and accept instructions.
- Let people provide information about their disability on their own initiative. They are not responsible for educating the public by sharing their story.
- Assistive devices (canes, wheelchairs, crutches, communication boards, etc.) should be regarded as private property. Ask if you can move any of them before doing so.
- Always direct communication **to the individual** with the disability - even if you are unsure they will understand you. If they are accompanied, do not direct your comments to the companion unless advised to do so.
- Allow service animals to accompany the person they support. Here is a link to The Rebbe's letter on allowing **service dogs** in synagogues.
https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/3771313/jewish/The-Rebbe-on-Allowing-Service-Dogs-In-Synagogues.htm